PDF Search

Search the full text of all your PDFs at once. Simple, fast and native to the Mac.

PDF Search is for one job: you have hundreds or thousands of PDFs, and you want to find every one that mentions a word or phrase, then jump straight to it. Drag in your folders, type, click. It also lets you search inside a PDF and highlight text, with highlights saved into the PDF just like in Preview.

It runs on macOS 13 (Ventura) or later, on Apple Silicon and Intel Macs.

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1. Installing

1. Open **PDF Search.dmg** and drag **PDF Search** onto the **Applications** folder.
2. Open it from Applications. The first time, macOS warns that it can't verify the app, because it isn't from the App Store or a registered Apple developer. Allow it once:
   - **macOS 15 or later:** click **Done** on the warning (not "Move to Trash"). Open **System Settings → Privacy & Security**, scroll down to *"PDF Search was blocked..."*, click **Open Anyway** and enter your password. Then open the app again and click **Open**.
   - **macOS 13–14:** right-click PDF Search in Applications, choose **Open**, then **Open** again.

> Terminal alternative: `xattr -dr com.apple.quarantine "/Applications/PDF Search.app"`

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2. Adding your PDFs

- **Drag folders or PDFs into the window** (or onto the app's Dock icon), or use **File → Add PDFs or Folders...** (`⌘O`) or the **+** button.
- The first time, PDF Search reads the text of every page. A progress bar shows how far it's got, and you can search while it works. Thousands of papers take a few minutes; after that, searches are instant.
- **Your PDFs stay where they are.** Nothing is copied or moved. PDF Search keeps only an index of their text.
- Folders you add are remembered. Each time the app opens (or when you press `⌘R`, *Rescan Folders*), it picks up new and changed PDFs and forgets deleted ones.

- Good folders to add: your Zotero library's `storage` folder (it shows up as "Zotero"), course readings, a downloaded proceedings collection.

> If a folder syncs with iCloud Drive or Google Drive, make sure its files are actually downloaded to the Mac. "Online-only" files can't be read.

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3. Searching

Type in the search box at the top of the sidebar. Results update as you type, best matches first. Each result shows a snippet with your words in bold and how many pages match.

YOU TYPE	IT FINDS
`glitch`	words *starting* with glitch: glitch, glitches, glitching
`glitch feedback`	pages containing *both* words, anywhere on the same page
`"circuit bending"`	that exact phrase
`cafe`	also Café. Accents and capitals don't matter
`art`	art, artifact, artist… but *not* "start" (matches begin at the start of a word)

- File names are searched too (the result says "in name").
- **Search in:** the menu above the results limits a search to one of your folders, or All PDFs. The ••• button next to it can rename a folder (just inside the app), show it in Finder, or remove it from the index.
- With the search box empty, the list shows every PDF in the current folder. Labels: *"no text"* means a scan without a text layer (not searchable); *"can't read"* means damaged or password-protected.
- In the list: click to view, double-click to open in Preview, right-click for *Show in Finder* or *Remove from Index*.

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4. Reading a PDF

- Click a result and the PDF opens at the first match, with every match marked in orange. These marks are temporary and never saved.
- Step through matches with ⌘G / ⇧⌘G or the arrows in the toolbar. The counter shows "3 of 12".

- **Zoom** by pinching on the trackpad. The zoom stays put, even when you open another PDF. `⌘0` or the *Zoom to Fit* button resets it.
- The *Open in Preview* button opens the file in your usual PDF app.

Find inside the open PDF (⌘F)

Already found the right paper and want to look for something else in it? Press `⌘F`. A find bar appears above the PDF; whatever you type is marked in that PDF (anywhere in a word, like Preview). `Return` or `⌘G` goes to the next match, `⇧⌘G` to the previous one. `Esc` or **Done** closes the bar and brings back your main search's marks.

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5. Highlighting

- Click the **highlighter** button in the toolbar (or press `^⌘H`). While it's on, any text you drag across or double-click becomes a highlight. Click it again to turn it off.
- To highlight one passage without the tool: select text, then `^⌘H` or right-click → **Highlight**.
- Pick a colour (yellow, green, blue, pink, purple) from the **palette** button.
- To remove one: right-click the highlight → **Remove Highlight**. There's no undo yet.
- Highlights are **saved into the PDF file automatically**, as standard PDF highlights, so they also appear in Preview, Zotero, Acrobat and other apps.

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6. Keyboard shortcuts

KEYS	ACTION
`⌘O`	Add PDFs or folders
`⌘R`	Rescan folders for new or changed PDFs
`⌘F`	Find inside the open PDF
`⌘G` / `⇧⌘G`	Next / previous match
`^⌘H`	Highlight the selection, or turn the highlighter on/off
`⌘0`	Zoom to fit

7. Good to know

- **Scanned PDFs** (pictures of pages) have no text to search until they're run through OCR, e.g. with Acrobat or a free OCR tool. They're labelled "no text".
- All search words must be on the **same page**.
- If you move or rename a folder you've added, remove it in the app (••• → Remove Folder from Index) and drag it in again.
- **Where the index lives:** `~/Library/Application Support/PDF Search/`. **File → Clear Index…** empties it; your PDFs are untouched.
- **To uninstall:** delete PDF Search from Applications, and optionally the folder above.

8. Extras in the download

- **Source Code:** the entire app is one Swift file. To build it yourself (no warnings on first launch), install Apple's command line tools (`xcode-select --install`) and double-click *Build PDF Search.command*. *Developer Notes.md* explains how it works and how to extend it.